

Session 3: The Gift of Personality Type

Summary:

Over the last 15 years I've studied many personality type systems. Some of the systems I've studied or created myself have proven to be very valuable.

These systems aren't about putting anyone "in a box." It's about identifying certain preferences and patterns each of us have. Don't pigeonhole yourself and think "This is the way I am, and I'll be this way forever." Instead, try seeing these models as just a useful way of identifying some of your strengths.

One of the most simple and powerful models I've learned is the 3 Brain Model. The idea here is we actually have 3 "brains" in one. At the brain stem is our Reptile Brain. It developed to interact with the physical world - to fight and to mate. On top of this brain we have the Mammalian Brain. This brain is about emotions - fear, anxiety, love, etc. It's what motivates us to love and care for our young, for example. Finally, on top of that, we have the Logical Brain (the Neocortex).

We have these 3 different brains, but they don't play very well together. For example, when you have a physical drive, that may conflict with your emotional conviction, and that may conflict with what you know is good for you. Internal conflict is often a conflict between these 3 brains.

Interestingly, these 3 brains correspond to 3 realms of life: the physical, the emotional, and the logical. Each of us tend to have strengths in some of these areas more than others. Think of a physical genius, compared to an emotional genius, compared to a logical genius.

Another interesting model is Carl Jung's theory, as interpreted through Myers-Briggs. In this model, there are 4 pairs of "preferences." See if you can see identify your preferences so you can narrow in on what your gifts are...

The first pair is Introversion/Extroversion. Introverts tend to recharge their batteries by being alone, prefer to mostly work alone, etc. Extroverts tend to recharge their batteries by being with other people, think out loud, work better being with others, etc.

Ask yourself, would you rather spend a weekend off alone, or with a big group of people who you don't know? That'll give you a clue to whether you're more Introverted or Extroverted.

The next pair is Sensor/Intuitive. There are two ways we take information in from the world. Some people prefer to use their 5 senses: how things look, smell, touch, etc. They tend to take things that people say literally. If they're looking at a forest with trees, they'll go up to an individual tree and study it. On the other hand, Intuitives look at situations and ask themselves, "What does this mean?" They're much more interested in looking at the forest as a whole.

The third pair is Feeling/Thinking. This refers to how we judge the world and make decisions. People who judge through feeling tend to be associated with their bodies. They're feeling their feelings all the time, and basing their decisions on them. Those who judge through thinking tend to be disassociated from their feelings. The thinker would say, "My emotions don't matter, what matters is doing the logical thing, the thing that makes sense..."

The final pair is Judging/Perceiving. You either judge first and perceive second, or perceive first and judge second. Judgers like to organize, plan, control. Perceivers, on the other hand, are "free spirits." They tend to be spontaneous, keep options open, delay decisions, etc. They are expert improvisers. Judgers like to control the external world, Perceivers like to control their internal world. Judgers like lists. Perceivers like to be spontaneous. Judgers are early, perceivers are late.

None of these preferences are "good" or "bad." They're all needed in the world. Each of them is a gift. A strength.

Exercise:

1. Are you primarily Physical, Emotional, or Logical? What's your secondary?
2. Make a list of things people like you are naturally talented at, and where they find success in the world. Take 20 minutes or so to develop your own thoughts on this.
3. Do you tend to identify more with Extroversion or Introversion? Sensing or Intuiting? Feeling or Thinking? Judging or Perceiving first?
4. Find the overlap between the talents you uncovered in this session, and the in-demand opportunities in the business world.